

# Lecture 1: Introduction — Power, Politics, and Political Science (MDJ)

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*Political Science — Master Notes · by Jakob V. Stangel*

**Required reading:** OD ch. 1 · Ansell (2023) ch. 1

**Core theme:** *What is politics, and how do we study it?* Two complementary lenses — OD gives you the **discipline's toolkit** (what comparative politics is + the main theory families), Ansell gives you a **single analytical engine** (political economy: self-interest → collective-action problems → the need for political "promises").

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## OD Ch. 1 — Introduction

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**Book:** Orvis & Drogus, *Introducing Comparative Politics: Concepts and Cases in Context*, 5th ed. (CQ Press/SAGE, 2021)

### Chapter résumé

The opening chapter defines the field and hands you the analytical vocabulary used for the rest of the book. It answers three "meta" questions — *what comparative politics is*, *why* to study it, and *how* comparativists do research — and then lays out the **three key questions** that organize the whole discipline: **What explains political behavior? Who rules? Where and why?** Most of the chapter is a guided tour of the competing **theory families** used to answer the first two questions. It closes with the book's plan (three parts) and its method of teaching through **eleven recurring country case studies**.

★ **The heart of the chapter:** the whole field collapses into **three questions** — *what explains behaviour?* · *who rules?* · *where & why?* — answered with the **Interests / Beliefs / Structures** and **Pluralist / Elite** frameworks, all read through **Lukes' three dimensions of power**. Master those and you can attack any comparative-politics question.

### Key concepts / "modes" to use

These are the analytical toolkits you're expected to *apply* to cases later:

- **Three dimensions of power** (Lukes) — the lens for spotting *where* power operates.
- **Empirical vs. normative theory** — always separate "what is" from "what *ought to be*."
- **Research methods** — single-case study · comparative method (most-similar / most-different systems) · quantitative statistics.
- **Explaining behavior** → **3 families:** Interests · Beliefs · Structures.
- **Who rules** → **2 families:** Pluralist vs. Elite theory.

## Section-by-section main points

### Comparative Politics: What Is It? / How to Study It?

*What is politics? (expanded with the lecture — MDJ)*

- **OD's definition:** politics = "*the process by which human communities make collective decisions*" (any scale, village → international body). This is a **procedural** definition — it's about *how* decisions get made, not their content. Four **implications**:
  - **Group, not private, decisions** — it concerns the group.
  - **The whole community** — decisions normally bind everyone.
  - **The process** — focus is on the decision-making *process*.
  - **≠ polity / policy** — distinguish **politics** (the process) from **polity** (the rules/institutions) and **policy** (the outcomes).
- Also: the process applies **across regime types**, needn't involve **large groups**, and is **not necessarily inclusive** (decisions are often made by small, unelected groups).
- **The distributional definitions** (what OD's definition leaves out — *the distribution of resources*):
  - **Lasswell (1936):** politics = "*who gets what, when, how.*"
  - **Easton (1953):** politics = "*the authoritative allocation of values for a society.*"
  - → politics as a **distributional game**: the capacity to distribute **material and non-material resources** (who wins, who loses).
  - Two key **assumptions** behind this view: ① **scarcity** of resources (no scarcity → no distributional battle) and ② **preference heterogeneity** (people want different, often conflicting, things).
- **Comparative politics** = the subfield comparing power & decision-making *within* countries (contrast: **international relations** studies *between/beyond* states).
- **Power — the three faces / dimensions.** *This is the chapter's master concept — it recurs as the lens for every theory later, so know it cold.* The lecture runs **one example** (a parliamentary **tax increase**) through all three so the differences are clear:

| Face                  | Who (attribution)        | Core idea                                                                                                    | The tax example                                                                                  | Power =                                |
|-----------------------|--------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|----------------------------------------|
| 1st · Decision-making | Dahl (1957)              | A gets B to do something B would not otherwise do — <b>observable</b> conflict & decisions                   | A majority in Parliament passes the tax increase despite strong opposition                       | <b>winning an observable decision</b>  |
| 2nd · Agenda-setting  | Bachrach & Baratz (1962) | Power through <b>non-decision-making</b> — keeping threatening issues <b>off the agenda</b> via rules/values | Powerful actors keep the tax increase off Parliament's agenda, so no debate or vote ever happens | <b>controlling what gets decided</b>   |
| 3rd · Ideological     | Lukes (1974)             | Shaping people's <b>wants, perceptions &amp; preferences</b> — even with <i>no observable conflict</i>       | People come to see taxing the wealthy as harmful/illegitimate, so the demand never even arises   | <b>shaping wants &amp; preferences</b> |

- **The difference in one line:** the 1st face is about *winning* a visible fight; the 2nd is about *stopping the fight from happening*; the 3rd is about *making sure no one wants to fight in the first place*. Power gets **less visible** as you go down.
- **Why it's central — the recurring pay-off:** each later theory is graded by *which dimension it can see*. Rational choice & pluralists see essentially only the **1st**; rational-choice institutionalists add the **2nd**; psychological theories, postmodern discourse, historical institutionalism and elite theory reach into the **2nd & 3rd**. Being able to say "this theory only captures the first dimension" is a core analytical move.
- **Worked example of the move (straight from the book):** *Rational choice* accepts people's preferences as **given** and only asks how they rationally pursue them — so it lives purely in the **1st dimension**, ignoring how preferences are *formed*. That is exactly why it "can't explain preferences in advance" and stumbles on the **cross-national union puzzle** (why French unions went communist while US unions chased only wages): it has no way to see the **3rd-dimensional** forces that *shaped* those preferences. **Psychological theories** and **historical institutionalists**, which do reach the 3rd dimension, are what step in to explain it. → *This is the template: name the theory, name the dimension(s) it can't see, then name a rival theory that reaches further.*

## Why Study Comparative Politics? — three benefits

1. Understand political events in specific countries (and inform foreign policy).
2. Draw **lessons** transferable from one place to another (e.g. presidential systems may worsen post-civil-war conflict — invisible if you only study the US).
3. Build **broad theories** of how politics works.

## How Do Comparativists Study Politics? — methods

- No lab: political actors *react* to being studied, so no perfect control.

- **Empirical theory** = explains what *does* occur (describe pattern → explain cause → predict).  
**Normative theory** = what *ought* to occur. The discipline is mostly empirical, but normative concerns shape which questions get asked (and that's legitimate).
- **Three research methods:**
  - **Single-case study** — deep dive into one case; generates/tests theory; *process tracing* links causes→effects; **deviant cases** expose theory limits. Never definitive beyond itself.
  - **Comparative method** — mimic the lab via careful case selection:
    - **Most-similar systems** — cases alike in many ways, differ on the key variable.
    - **Most-different systems** — cases differing in many ways but sharing the outcome (e.g. revolutions: France, Russia, China, Iran...).
  - **Quantitative statistical techniques** — reduce evidence to numbers, compare hundreds of cases (e.g. the civil-war & diamonds study: civil war driven more by *lootable resources* than ethnicity).
- **Scientific-method vocabulary:** theory · hypothesis · variable · **dependent** vs **independent** variable · control.
- Best modern scholarship *combines* methods (quant for patterns + case studies for causal depth).

## Three Key Questions in Comparative Politics

1. What explains political behavior? (core of all political science)
2. Who rules?
3. Where and why? (comparativists' distinctive contribution — the same explanation across different times/places?)

## Q1 — What Explains Political Behavior? → three answer-families

The chapter's (and the exam's) core. Each family splits into competing theories — below, each with its **core idea**, its **critique**, and which **face of power** it "sees." Learn the theory names + one line each.

### ① Interests — behaviour = actors pursuing their own preferences

| Theory                 | Core idea                                                                                                                                                                       | Critique                                                                                                                                                        | Sees face |
|------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-----------|
| <b>Rational choice</b> | Rational individuals pursue self-defined <b>preferences</b> instrumentally (borrowed from economics; starts at the individual).                                                 | Can't know preferences <b>in advance</b> → weak predictive power; struggles with cross-country variation. Group-behaviour critics: <b>Achen &amp; Bartels</b> . | 1st       |
| <b>Psychological</b>   | <b>Non-rational</b> factors — personal experience, <b>emotions</b> , personality — shape behaviour ( <b>Petersen</b> on fear; <b>Hetherington &amp; Weiler</b> on personality). | Its focus on the individual makes <b>group</b> behaviour hard to explain.                                                                                       | 3rd       |

### ② Beliefs — behaviour = values & ideas

| Theory                    | Core idea                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                        | Critique                                                                                                                                 | Sees face |
|---------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-----------|
| <b>Political culture</b>  | Shared <b>attitudes, values, symbols</b> shape behaviour. <i>Modernist</i> : clear, identifiable civic values (Almond & Verba's <b>civic culture</b> ; <b>postmaterialist</b> shift, Inglehart). <i>Postmodernist</i> : culture = symbols open to interpretation in <b>discourse</b> (Foucault). | Do countries really have <i>one</i> culture? Culture may be an <b>effect</b> , not a cause; postmodernism accused of explaining nothing. | 2nd–3rd   |
| <b>Political ideology</b> | A <b>systematic, conscious belief-set</b> guides action (liberalism, communism, fascism).                                                                                                                                                                                                        | May just <b>justify</b> actions really driven by <u>self-interest</u> or culture.                                                        | 3rd       |

### ③ Structures — behaviour = shaped & limited by broad structures

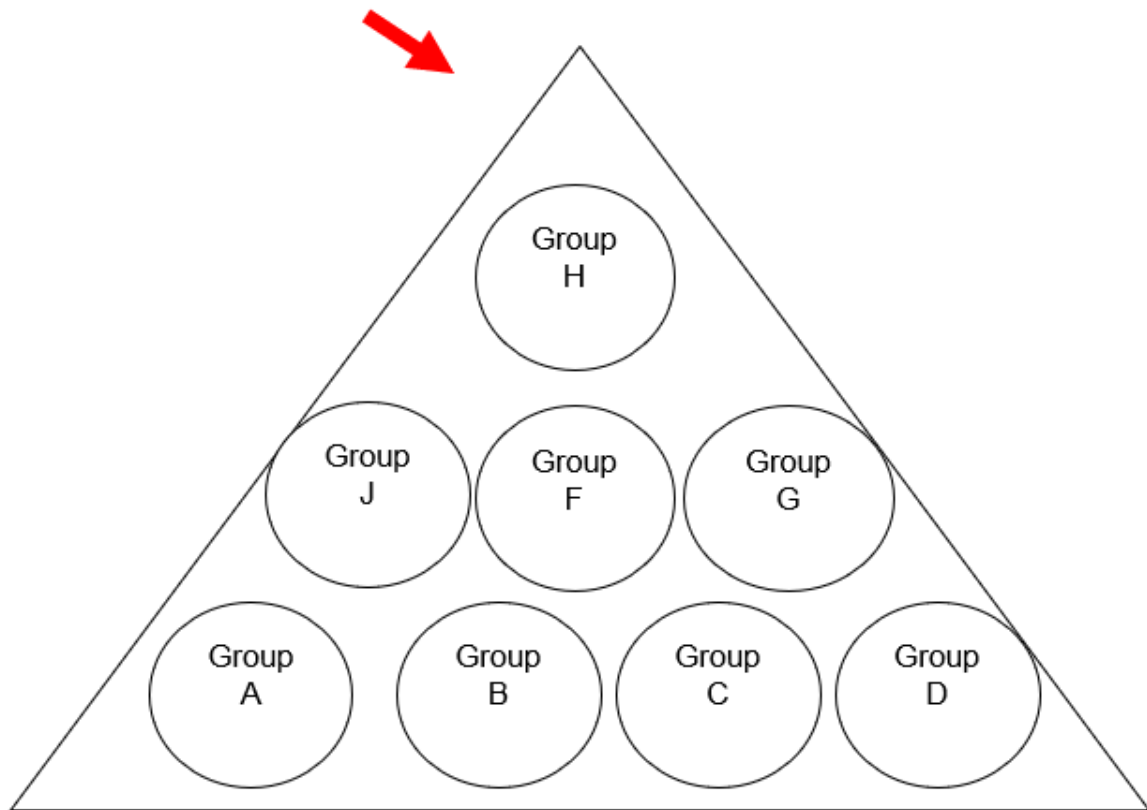
| Theory                  | Core idea                                                                                                                                                                                                                                  | Critique                                                                                            | Sees face                     |
|-------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-------------------------------|
| <b>Marxism</b>          | Behaviour explained by <b>class conflict</b> rooted in the economic system (bourgeoisie vs proletariat — <b>Marx</b> ).                                                                                                                    | Overlooks <b>non-economic</b> motives (religion, nationalism) and other sources of power.           | 2nd–3rd                       |
| <b>Institutionalism</b> | <b>Institutions — the "rules of the game"</b> — shape behaviour ( <i>rational-choice institutionalist</i> , <b>Weingast</b> ; <i>historical institutionalist</i> , <b>Haggard &amp; Kaufman</b> ; e.g. the <u>US two-term tradition</u> ). | Institutions may <b>reflect</b> <u>self-interest</u> or culture rather than <i>cause</i> behaviour. | 2nd (RC) / all 3 (historical) |

## Q2 — Who Rules? → two answer-families

- **Pluralist theories** (classic statement: **Robert Dahl**, *Who Governs?* 1961) — society = many competing groups; power *dispersed*; no group wins permanently; policy = compromise. (Thinks mostly in the **1st dimension** of power.) Claims to apply even to authoritarian states (Soviet factions; African patron–client networks).
- **Elite theories** — every society ruled by a small elite controlling ~all power (uses **2nd & 3rd dimensions**). Variants:
  - **Marxism** — ruling class = owners of the economy (bourgeoisie); state = "executive committee of the bourgeoisie."
  - **Power elite** (C. Wright Mills) — interlocking economic + political + military elites.
  - **Oligarchy** (Winters) — extreme wealth as power, used to protect wealth.
  - **Patriarchy** (feminist) — rule by men; politics/military tied to masculinity.
  - **Racial elite** / "**new Jim Crow**" (Alexander) — one race maintains dominance via law, wealth, discourse.
- **Test for who rules:** Who holds formal power? Who influences decisions? Who benefits? → few = elite; many = pluralist.

Visualising it (from the lecture):

Multiple groups hold and compete over power:  
No singular center of power



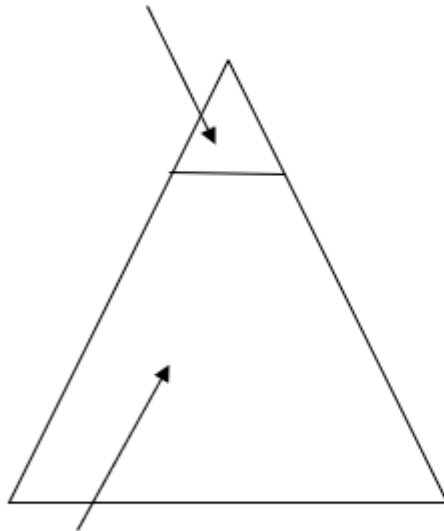
- Multiple groups, but few (elites) hold power

**Elite:**

Government,  
corporations.

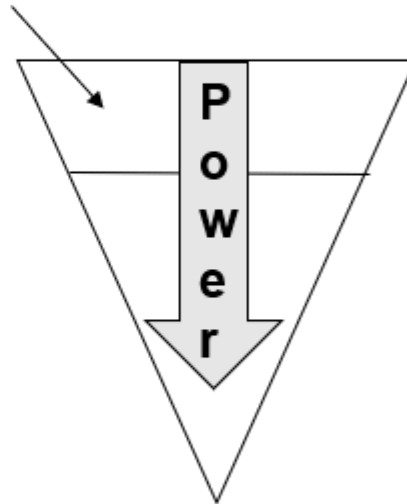
**Elite power:**

- Disproportional to size
- Governs society



**Society: Public, organisations**

- Largest group(s) with little power



**How to read them.** *Pluralist* (first diagram): power is **dispersed** among many competing groups — *no single centre*. *Elitist* (second): a **small elite** (government, corporations) sits at the top and holds power **disproportionate** to its size, while the **largest group** — the **public/society** — **has little power**; the inverted triangle shows **power flowing down** onto them. Same society, opposite claim about where power really sits.

### Q3 — Where and Why?

- Add the **comparative dimension** to Q1 & Q2: why do welfare states differ (see the Sweden vs US welfare state case)? Explanations compete — rational choice / ideology / institutions. Comparison across cases reveals patterns a single case hides.

### Plan of the Book

- **Part I** — the state (what it is, strong/weak; state–citizen–regime; state–identity).
- **Part II** — how political systems work (democratic & authoritarian institutions; participation; regime change).
- **Part III** — political economy & policy.

- **11 recurring country cases:** 4 wealthy democracies (Britain, Germany, Japan, US); 2 post-communist (China, Russia); largest enduring democracy (India); the one theocracy (Iran); 3 post-authoritarian democracies (Brazil, Mexico, Nigeria).

## Cases & examples

The concrete cases the chapter uses. Each one: *what actually happened* → *what it illustrates*.

- **Tunisia vs Syria (2011).** Both were swept up in the Arab Spring protests, yet the outcomes split completely: Tunisia negotiated a relatively **peaceful transition to democracy**, while Syria collapsed into a long, brutal **civil war**. → *Illustrates:* why comparison matters — understanding a country's internal dynamics has real foreign-policy stakes; it also undercuts the lazy claim that "Arab/Islamic culture" is uniformly anti-democratic (same culture-family, opposite results).
- **Post-civil-war presidentialism.** Americans treat their directly-elected presidency as *the* stable model. But in a country just out of civil war it's **winner-take-all**: only one side's candidate can win the top job, so the losers may prefer to **restart the war** than live with the result. A **power-sharing** system that gives every major group a slice of national power tends to be safer. → *Illustrates:* a lesson you simply cannot see by studying the US alone — the payoff of comparison.
- **Civil war & diamonds** (Collier & Hoeffler; **Sierra Leone**). A large **quantitative** study of hundreds of civil wars found that **ethnic division is not the main cause** people assume. War is far more likely where a group can seize a **valuable, lootable resource** — like the diamonds fuelling Sierra Leone's 1990s war. Where there's no such prize, ethnic division rarely turns violent. → *Illustrates:* the quantitative method + a genuinely counter-intuitive finding.
- **Ukraine 2014 — "is it a civil war?"** When fighting erupted in 2014 (with a Russian military presence backing one side), scholars couldn't cleanly classify it: *how much* violence, for *how long*, before it "counts" as a civil war? → *Illustrates:* the hard first step of any scientific study — **defining and measuring your variables** precisely.
- **Almond & Verba, The Civic Culture (1963).** They surveyed citizens across five countries and argued that stable democracies (US, UK) share a "**civic culture**" — people participate *and* defer enough to let leaders govern — whereas **Mexico** had a "**subject**" culture (citizens saw themselves as subjects, not participants), fitting its authoritarian rule until 2000. → *Illustrates:* the classic **modernist** political-culture claim — and the standard critique that culture may be an *effect* of institutions, not their cause.
- **US Catholics shifting Democrat → Republican.** Mid-20th-c. working-class Catholics voted **Democrat** on economic interest. As they grew affluent, they came to prioritise **moral/cultural** issues (e.g. abortion) and drifted **Republican**. → *Illustrates:* **postmaterialism** (Inglehart) — political culture changing over time and reshaping party alignments.
- **"Family values" (Reagan vs Clinton).** No US politician dares oppose "family values," yet the phrase has **no fixed meaning**: Reagan's Republicans used it to claim the traditional middle-class family; Clinton's Democrats **reinterpreted** it to mean single mothers and two-income families needing afterschool programmes. → *Illustrates:* the **postmodernist** point — political symbols are contested and redefined through **discourse** (a play for the 3rd dimension of power).
- **Unions: France / US / UK.** Same institution, three preference-sets: **French** unions tied themselves to the **Communist Party** and pursued broad ideological goals; **US** unions stayed "bread-and-butter" (wages & conditions), shunning socialist parties; **British** unions built their own **Labour Party**. →

*Illustrates:* the puzzle for **rational choice** — it takes preferences as given, so it can't explain *why* they differ so sharply across countries (this is the worked example above).

- **US two-term tradition** (Washington → FDR). Washington voluntarily stepped down after two terms; **no president broke the norm for 150+ years** until FDR won a third term in **1940** — after which it was written into the Constitution (22nd Amendment). → *Illustrates:* an **informal institution** that shaped behaviour purely because leaders and citizens believed it *should*.
- **Chile's democratic transition (1990s)**. One of the most successful exits from military rule — explained three different ways: **rational-choice institutionalists** (elites cut a strategic constitutional bargain that served their interests), **political-culture** theorists (Chilean values favoured democracy), **historical institutionalists** (Chile could revive its earlier stable democratic institutions, a legacy neighbours lacked). → *Illustrates:* how the **same event** gets three competing explanations — and the analyst's job is to weigh them.
- **Sweden vs US welfare state**. Sweden runs a large, expensive welfare state; the US spends far less. Why do two rich democracies diverge? **Interests:** strong labour won in Sweden, business overpowered labour in the US. **Beliefs:** Sweden's dominant Socialists spread social-democratic ideology; US "make it on your own" culture rejects socialism. **Institutions:** Sweden's unified labour body (LO) became central to policymaking; US unions stayed decentralised and weak. → *Illustrates:* the lead "**Where and why?**" puzzle, with one answer from each theory family.
- **US corporate power / oligarchy** (Winters). Is the US genuinely democratic if a **corporate elite** holds outsized power? Winters argues extreme wealth ("material power") lets **oligarchs** hire lawyers and lobbyists to shield their income from redistribution. → *Illustrates:* a "**Who rules?**" case pitting elite theory against pluralism.

**The 11 recurring countries** (used across the whole book): Britain, Germany, Japan, USA (wealthy democracies) • China, Russia (post-communist) • India (largest democracy) • Iran (theocracy) • Brazil, Mexico, Nigeria (post-authoritarian).

## Key terms

| Term                                | Meaning                                                                                                      |
|-------------------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Politics                            | Process by which communities make collective decisions (procedural; group, whole community, ≠ polity/policy) |
| Polity / Policy                     | The rules & institutions / the outcomes (vs <i>politics</i> = the process)                                   |
| Distributional game                 | Politics as allocating resources — "who gets what" (Lasswell; Easton)                                        |
| Scarcity / Preference heterogeneity | The two assumptions behind the distributional view of politics                                               |
| Comparative politics                | Subfield comparing power/decision-making across countries                                                    |
| Three faces of power                | (1) decision-making, Dahl; (2) agenda-setting, Bachrach & Baratz; (3) ideological, Lukes                     |
| Empirical / Normative theory        | Explains what <i>does</i> / what <i>ought to</i> occur                                                       |
| Single-case study                   | Deep study of one case (uses process tracing)                                                                |
| Comparative method                  | Careful case selection: most-similar vs most-different systems                                               |
| Rational choice theory              | Actors rationally pursue self-defined preferences                                                            |
| Political culture                   | Widely held attitudes/values/symbols about politics                                                          |
| Civic culture                       | Culture supporting stable democracy (Almond & Verba)                                                         |
| Political ideology                  | Conscious systematic belief-set about how politics <i>ought to</i> be                                        |
| Institutionalism                    | Institutions ("rules of the game") explain behavior                                                          |
| Pluralist theory                    | Power dispersed among competing groups                                                                       |
| Elite theory                        | A small elite controls virtually all power                                                                   |
| Patriarchy                          | Rule by men                                                                                                  |

## Exam pointers

- Be able to **apply the 3 dimensions of power** to an example, and say which theory family "sees" which dimension.
  - Know the **Interests / Beliefs / Structures** trichotomy for Q1 and **Pluralist vs Elite** for Q2 — with one named theorist per box (the names are in the two tables above: e.g. Interests → *Achen & Bartels / Petersen*; Beliefs → *Almond & Verba, Inglehart, Foucault*; Structures → *Marx, Weingast*; Pluralist → *Dahl*; Elite → *Mills, Winters, Alexander*).
  - Distinguish **most-similar vs most-different** systems designs with an example.
  - Always flag **empirical vs normative** when a question mixes them.
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# Ansell — *Why Politics Fails*, Ch. 1

**Book:** Ben Ansell (2023), *Why Politics Fails: The Five Traps of the Modern World – and How to Escape Them*, Penguin.

*Note:* the provided PDF is titled "**Introduction: Simple Problems, Impossible Politics**" — this is the framing chapter the syllabus lists as "chapter 1." It sets up the whole book.

## Chapter résumé

Ansell argues that our biggest challenges (climate change is the opening example) are often "**simple problems with impossible politics**": we understand the solution but can't get people to act. The reason is political economy — individuals are **self-interested**, and self-interest predictably collides with the collective good, producing **collective-action problems**. He introduces the **five goals** we broadly agree on — **Democracy, Equality, Solidarity, Security, Prosperity** — each of which is also a **trap**. Politics is fundamentally about making **collective promises** to each other; but promises can't be externally enforced, so they only work when made self-enforcing through **institutions** and **norms**. The book's project: learn to spot the five traps and escape them.

★ **The heart of the chapter:** one chain explains why politics fails — **self-interest** → **collective-action problem** → **tragedy of the commons** → **the need for self-enforcing political promises** (institutions & norms). If you learn one thing here, learn to run that chain.

## Key concepts / "modes" to use

- Political economy — model individuals as self-interested utility-maximizers, then scale up to society.
- Self-interest → preferences → constraints → trade-offs — the micro engine.
- Collective-action problem — self-interested individuals undermine a shared goal.
- Tragedy of the commons & externalities (negative/positive) — the recurring failure shapes.
- Politics as promises — collective, unenforceable, needing self-enforcing design.
- **Institutions** (formal rules) & **norms** (informal expectations) — what makes promises stick.
- The Five Traps: Democracy · Equality · Solidarity · Security · Prosperity.

## Section-by-section main points

### Opening — Simple Problems, Impossible Politics

- Climate change: science is a century old and well understood; the road from emissions → warming is *simple*. The hard part is getting anyone to act — a **global problem with domestic politics**. No world government to enforce, so everyone free-rides.
- International attempts show politics *can* work (Paris 2015) or fail (Kyoto, Copenhagen) — success came from flexibility, vague wording, deferral.

- Climate tests all **five** goals: democracy (global consensus?), equality (should richer pay more?), solidarity (do rich nations owe poor?), security (climate refugees, enforcement?), prosperity (short-term gain vs long-term survival).

## Common ground

- **Politics** = how we make collective decisions / make promises to each other in an uncertain world. Essential for solving shared dilemmas.
- **Double-edged sword**: we need politics but hate it; we look for alternatives (markets, technology, strong leaders) but these are "**false gods**" — they still run into human disagreement.
- Disagreement is **inevitable** (elections have losers; spending is unequal; who guards the guards?). Push politics down in one place, it pops up elsewhere ("paste in the toothpaste tube").
- Despite polarization, most people **agree on five things** — which are also five **traps**.

## The five goals (each a trap)

- **Democracy** — right/ability of the mass public to choose and replace leaders.  $\sim\frac{1}{2}$  the world lives in democracies; broadly popular (86% in World Values Survey favor it) but under pressure (the "third wave" stalled; populism, referendums, attacks on media/expertise).
- **Equality** — everyone treated the same; but debate over *outcomes* vs *opportunities* and redistribution. Wide consensus that income gaps are too large (2019: only 7% disagreed), yet inequality has *risen* in rich countries since the 1980s → populist backlash ("inequality paradox").
- **Solidarity** — support for fellow citizens in hard times (illness, bad luck). Underpins popular "third-rail" policies (US Social Security, UK NHS). COVID-19 showed global health interdependence.
- **Security** — the most basic desire: to be safe. 70% prefer security over freedom (highest where war is recent). Concerns: violence *within* states, police violence ("who guards us from our protectors?"), return of interstate war (Ukraine).
- **Prosperity** — enough money to live/grow; but endless growth warms the planet → trade-off between prosperity and environmental survival.

## Political economy (the method)

- The school of thought taking seriously how individual and society interact: start with a **model of each of us** (what we want + how we plan to get it), then pan out to society and watch **best-laid plans undermined by... us**.
- **Basic model**: everyone is **self-interested** — has ordered **preferences** and tries to **maximize utility** (pick the highest-value option). Not an ethical claim — a *predictive analytical tool*.
- **Methodological individualism**: start from individuals, not classes/cultures/groups.
- **Constraints & trade-offs**: you can't have everything (physical, institutional, social limits) → every choice sacrifices an alternative (coffee vs tea; lower taxes vs social liberalism at the ballot box).
- Even **voting** is a puzzle: your single vote is unlikely to be decisive, so turnout must be partly explained by a sense of **duty**. Politicians too are self-interested (must win elections → campaign arms race).

- Studying self-interest is **liberating**, not cynical: even apparently selfless behavior often has a self-interested logic (e.g. the rich opposing public-education spending that "devalues" their kids' advantage).

## Collective-action problems

- When self-interested individuals interact, they can inadvertently wreck a shared goal.
- **Example — the Cod Wars** (Britain vs Iceland, 1950s–70s): overfishing a shared resource.
- **Tragedy of the commons**: without ownership, everyone fishes freely → stocks collapse; my self-interest hurts yours.
- **Externalities**: a market action's effect on a third party — mostly **negative** (pollution, congestion), sometimes **positive** (a neighbor's rose garden). Political life is "full of externalities."
- Root cause: we are **interdependent** — my choice affects your options — and we can't commit others (or ourselves) to "do the right thing." *The making of a tragedy.*

## Politics as a promise

- We're *smart*: we anticipate what others will do — which is exactly why collective-action problems arise (can't blame "stupidity").
- Politics = making **collective promises** (politicians→voters, allies→adversaries). A **promise** ≠ a **contract**: it **can't be legally enforced by a third party** — there's *no higher power than politics itself*.
- So political promises are **fragile and temporary**; they succeed only when self-enforcing — designed so that reneging is hard.
- Two tools to grant promises permanence:
  - **Institutions** — formal rules/organizations that lock in expectations (e.g. the **US Senate filibuster**: powerful, flawed, over-represents small states, hard to remove safely — shows institutions structure behavior even when dysfunctional).
  - **Norms** — informal expectations about how we should behave; invisible but powerful, vaguer and harder to enforce than rules; not every leader can invoke them.
- Because institutions & norms vary, **politics plays out differently around the world** (e.g. Nordic high-trust, inclusive systems are hard to transplant).

## The traps (close)

- Each of the five goals faces a **trap triggered by self-interest** that blocks the collective goal. Traps aren't destiny — but they're **insidious, pervasive, even enticing**.
- Two options: spot the traps "in the wild" and step around them, or — if already caught — learn to **escape**. *Only by understanding why politics fails can we make it succeed.*

**The chain, run once (worked).** This is the single argument the whole chapter builds — here it is end-to-end on the Cod Wars:

1. **Self-interest**. Every fisherman, British and Icelandic, tries to maximise his *own* catch (the political-economy starting model).

2. → **Collective-action problem**. They're **interdependent** — fishing the *same* sea — so each one acting on self-interest undermines the shared goal (a sustainable stock). Individually rational, collectively ruinous.
3. → **Tragedy of the commons** / externality. The sea is **unowned and hard to monitor**, so no one can be excluded → everyone overfishes → the stock collapses (tragedy of the commons). Put the other way: my extra catch imposes a cost on you — a **negative externality**.
4. → **Need for political promises**. We'd all be better off with a binding catch limit, but there's **no world government** to enforce one — so the *states* must make **political promises** to each other on behalf of their fishermen.
5. → **Institutions & norms**. A promise can't be enforced by any third party, so it only holds if it's self-enforcing — locked in by **institutions** (formal rules: recognised fishing limits/zones) and **norms** (informal expectations). When Iceland kept *extending* its limits, the promise broke and new ones were needed — "*politics never ends*."

**Reusable template (works on any trap):** name the self-interest → show the **interdependence** that makes it a collective-action problem → identify the **commons/externality** failure → state the **promise** that would fix it → name the **institution/norm** that could make the promise stick.

## Key terms

| Term                      | Meaning                                                            |
|---------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Political economy         | Study of how self-interested individuals and society interact      |
| Self-interest             | Model assumption: people pursue their own ordered preferences      |
| Utility maximization      | Choosing the option that yields the highest personal value         |
| Constraint / trade-off    | Limits force sacrifice of one option for another                   |
| Collective-action problem | Self-interested individuals undermine a shared goal                |
| Tragedy of the commons    | Unowned shared resource gets over-exploited                        |
| Externality               | Effect of a transaction on a third party (negative/positive)       |
| Politics-as-promise       | Collective promises that no third party can enforce                |
| Self-enforcing            | Arrangement where reneging is made costly/hard                     |
| Institution               | Formal rule/organization locking in expectations (e.g. filibuster) |
| Norm                      | Informal expectation about proper behavior                         |
| The Five Traps            | Democracy, Equality, Solidarity, Security, Prosperity              |

## Exam pointers

- Memorize the **five goals/traps** (Democracy, Equality, Solidarity, Security, Prosperity) — the spine of the whole book.

- Be able to **run the chain**: self-interest → collective-action problem → tragedy of the commons/externalities → need for political promises → institutions & norms (*worked end-to-end above*).
- Use the **Cod Wars** / tragedy of the commons as your go-to worked example.
- Key distinction: a **promise** (unenforceable, needs to be self-enforcing) vs a **contract** (third-party enforced).

## Bridge to OD

Both readings converge on **institutions** and on modelling actors via **interests/self-interest** (OD's "Interests" family = Ansell's political-economy engine). Ansell's "politics = collective decisions" is almost verbatim OD's definition of **politics**. Good to cite them together on *why institutions matter*.

## ★ Fun facts & memorable details

The sticky examples, surprising stats and quotable lines from this module — the stuff worth dropping into an essay or exam answer.

### Memorable examples (great to cite)

- **The Cod Wars** (Britain vs Iceland, 1950s–70s): two NATO allies clashing over cod — boats rammed, one accidental death by electrocution, and Icelandic coastguards fitting **wire-cutters** to slash British trawler nets. A perfect little tragedy-of-the-commons story. (*Ansell*)
- **Civil war & diamonds**: statistical research (Collier & Hoeffler) found civil wars are driven more by control of **lootable resources** — diamonds, e.g. Sierra Leone — than by ethnic division. (*OD*)
- **The "new Jim Crow"** (Michelle Alexander): mass incarceration reframed as a modern system of racial control. (*OD*)
- **George Washington's two-term tradition**: an *informal* institution that held for 150+ years until FDR broke it in 1940 — then it was locked into the Constitution. (*OD*)
- **"Family values"** as a contested symbol — Reagan's Republicans and Clinton's Democrats each reinterpreted it (the postmodernist point about discourse). (*OD*)

### Surprising stats

- **86%** worldwide (World Values Survey) say democracy is a good way to run a country — and in **China, Ethiopia, Iran & Tajikistan over 90%** agree with pro-democracy statements, *more* than in the US. (*Ansell*)
- **~70%** say they'd prefer **security over freedom** — highest where war is recent. (*Ansell*)
- **~95%** across wealthy countries think government should provide healthcare — even **85% in the US**. (*Ansell*)
- **2016** was, by some counts, the **most violent year since WWII**. (*Ansell*)

### Quotable lines

- Marx: the modern state is "*the executive committee of the whole bourgeoisie*." (*OD*)

- Keynes: "*In the long run we are all dead.*" — on why forecasting fails. (Ansell)
- Ansell on the inescapability of politics: push it down in one place and it pops up in another, "*like the proverbial paste in the toothpaste tube.*"
- The **NHS** as Britain's "*national religion.*" (Ansell)

#### Trivia

- OD's example of why natural science can be "purer": South Korea's **Woo Suk Hwang** **faked stem-cell results** — but biologists don't get *normatively* attached to findings the way political scientists do.
  - The CO<sub>2</sub>-warming theory dates to **1861**, revived in a **1956 New York Times** piece imagining "tigers roaming... and squawking Arctic parrots." (Ansell)
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